1778; but my noting the dimensions of the windows, etc., so enraged the keeper, that he would not indulge my curiosity any farther. 30 May, 1783, I found one debtor; and was informed that there were three prisoners in the dungeons.

There is at Ghent a new prison building by the States of Austrian Flanders. It is a house of correction for those provinces (as that at Vilvorde for Austrian Brabant) and is called La Maison de Force.[1] It is situated near a canal. The plan is an octagon ; only four sides finished: in one of them were, in 1775, one hundred and fifty-nine men criminals: in 1776, one hundred and ninety-one. Another of the sides is for women, of whom there were fifty-nine. In the middle of this court is a basin of water, for washing the linen of the house.

On each of the four floors there is a corridor, or arcade, six feet nine inches wide, quite open to the air of the court; which, however, is not attended with any inconvenience, even in winter. In the recess of every corridor, except the lowest, is a range of bedrooms, six feet ten inches by five feet four, and seven feet eight inches high: the doorway two feet. These are uniformly furnished with a bedstead (six feet and a half by two and a half), a straw bed, a mattress, a pillow, a pair of sheets, two blankets in winter, and one in summer. Each room has a little bench, and a shutter to the lattice window (nineteen inches by fifteen, in the door) which, when opened and turned down, serves for a table. In the wall is a little cupboard, two feet by one, and ten inches deep. All the rooms are vaulted, to prevent fire from running from story to story. No person is on any pretence admitted into the bedroom of another. They have a clean shirt once a week, and clean sheets once a month. The women have not separate rooms. Some of theirs are ten feet and a half by nine and a half.

In order to the admission of a prisoner, previous notice must be given by the city or province that sends him. When he comes, he is shaved and washed: a surgeon examines him; and if healthy, he is clothed with the uniform of the house, viz., a linen coat and breeches, and cloth waistcoat, which are marked with the number of his room; to it he is conducted by one of the most orderly of the prisoners; who is appointed to that service, and who also acquaints him with the rules of the house. Commitment from one year to twenty or more, according to their crimes.

A bell is rung in the morning to summon the prisoners into the dining-room; in the summer at five; in winter the hour varies

[1] This prison is still in use [Ed.].

with the length of the days. Half an hour after the bell rings, their names are called over; and they go to prayers in a chapel. They are then allowed half an hour to breakfast. At noon they have two hours for dinner, making their beds (which in fair weather they bring out to air) and for recreation. I was present during the whole time the men criminals were at dinner, and much admired the regularity, decency, and order, with which the whole was conducted. Everything was done at a word given by a director; no noise or confusion appeared; and this company of near one hundred and ninety stout criminals was governed with as much apparent ease, as the most sober and well-disposed assembly in civil society. At night they have an hour for supper, etc. The bell gives notice of all these successive hours: it is rung at a window over the gateway by a sentinel, who there overlooks the whole court; and, should there be any disturbance, is to give the alarm to a company who keep guard. There are eight small rooms (*cachots*) without beds, for the punishment of the refractory; but I always found them empty.

On the ground-floors of the building are workrooms. Those for the men are too small for the looms, etc. The women's workroom is one hundred and seventy feet long, twenty-six wide, and nine to the springing of the arch. In this, many were spinning and combing wool, mending linen, etc. Others were washing the linen in places proper for that purpose.

An exact account is kept of every circumstance relating to each man's work, in a book that has fourteen columns.

1. Contains the names of prisoners.
2. The sort of stuff on which each man is employed; as shalloon, cloth, dimity, etc.
3. The number that is marked on the piece.
4. The day it was begun.
5. The day it was finished.
6. Measure of the whole piece.
7. Number of working days the prisoner was upon it.
8. The task due per day.
9. Surplus work upon the piece beyond task.
10. Price of the piece per ell.
11. Observations, on occasional circumstances: such as sick, lame, difficult work, first piece, etc.
12. Payment to prisoners for surplus work.
13. Deficiency of task.
14. Punishment for the default.